Our brigade came directly under the Corps HQ. Lieutenant General M.A. Zaki, who was our corps commander, told me to carry out operational reconnaissance of all my tasks without worrying about the snow conditions. So I had to go on foot from the main road to the top of various hills, through knee-deep snow at places. This exercise was better than any treadmill and I got to know my area of responsibility, besides getting fit quickly. It was a dramatic change of scene from the peaceful environment of Algeria, and it didn't take me long to forget all about Algiers.

On being given any assignment, it has been my principle to convey my professional key result areas (KRAs) and concepts to my subordinate commanders and staff officers, as soon as I have got the picture myself. Therefore, I held a conference within a fortnight of my assuming command of the brigade. During this interaction, first, the operational and administrative issues were covered by my staff, then the commanding officers briefed me about the state of their units, and finally, I gave out my directions and policy. My first KRA was that we should have a high state of operational readiness. The next were training and administration issues. We were aware that many Kashmiri and foreign terrorists had infiltrated into J&K in the previous one or two years. They had also carried out some violent acts in the recent past. There were indications that the situation was likely to worsen. Therefore, I impressed on my battalion commanders that the stakes were very high, and that the challenge was to be met by the highest standards of leadership by all of us. As such, we needed to reorient ourselves and our commands to undertake counterterrorist operations. We must accord the highest importance to human rights while carrying out any task, I added, at the same time laying great emphasis on honest reporting.

Within a few days, we were tasked by the Corps HQ to rescue some people taken hostage by a small group of terrorists at Kokernag. One of my battalions, located nearby at Khanabal, on the outskirts of Anantnag, was asked to plan and execute the task. The CO decided to send two companies under the second-in-command to undertake this operation. The plan was to move close to the objective in two prongs, and thereafter advance on foot and cordon